

THE 2026 MONEY PLAYBOOK SERIES

The Smart Credit Card Playbook 2026

India Edition · Earn maximum rewards, stack festive offers, and never fall into the minimum-due trap

- Card-by-card 2026 rewards map
- Festive-sale bank offers decoded
- The minimum-due trap maths
- Your RBI rights, in plain English

Verified against official sources · October 2026

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Before you start

Read This First

This playbook is written for one person: an Indian cardholder who wants the rewards and the festive-sale discounts without ever paying 40% interest. It is deliberately short on theory and long on numbers you can act on today. Every card rate, cap, rule and offer below was checked against official issuer terms, RBI directions and platform offer pages in October 2026.

Two honest warnings before you spend a rupee. First, credit cards reward discipline, not spending — the entire reward on a typical card is worth 1% to 5%, while the interest on an unpaid balance runs at 39% to 50% a year. Rewards are the small print; interest is the big print. Second, card terms change constantly, so treat every number here as a verified snapshot and confirm the current terms in your card's Most Important Terms and Conditions (MITC) before you apply or spend.

This is education, not advice

Nothing here is personalised financial advice and no card is recommended for you personally. Use the method, check your own MITC, and decide what fits your spending. For a decision this personal, a licensed adviser can help.

What is inside

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Chapter 1

The One Rule That Decides Everything

Almost everything you have heard about credit cards — the cashback, the reward points, the lounge access, the 10% festive discounts — sits on top of a single number: whether you pay the full statement amount by the due date. Do that, and your card is the cheapest short-term credit you will ever get, plus free rewards. Miss it, and the same card becomes one of the most expensive loans in Indian personal finance.

Why paying in full is the whole game

A credit card gives you an interest-free period — a window in which you are using the bank's money for free. The window runs from the day you make a purchase to the payment due date of the statement that carries it. Understanding that window is the difference between a free 45-day float and a 50% annual interest bill.

- The billing cycle is the gap between two statement dates, usually about 30 days; each purchase lands on one statement, due 15 to 20 days after it closes.
- A purchase made just after your statement closes gets almost the full cycle plus the grace period — up to about 45 to 50 interest-free days; one made just before it closes gets only 15 to 20 days.
- The lever: time large purchases to the start of the billing cycle to stretch the free credit the longest.

Your one-line rule

Set auto-pay for the total amount due — never the minimum due. If you cannot clear the full statement this month, that purchase did not belong on a credit card.

What happens the moment you pay less than the full amount

The instant you leave a balance outstanding, three things happen at once — and they are why the interest cost is so much worse than it looks:

1. The interest-free period is suspended. Interest is charged on the unpaid balance from each transaction date — retroactively, not from the due date.
2. Every new purchase also loses its grace period and starts earning interest from day one, until you clear the full balance.
3. The interest compounds monthly, and 18% GST is added on top of every finance charge — so the number on the card is not the number you pay.

RBI now forces issuers to print a warning on every statement that making only the minimum payment will stretch your repayment over months or years with compounded interest. That warning is the most important sentence on your bill.

One free fix: RBI's card directions let you change your card's billing cycle at least once, to any date. If your due date falls before your salary, move it to just after your payday — that alone removes the most common reason people miss a payment.

Chapter 2

How to Choose the Right Card

There is no single best credit card in India — only the best card for your spending. The card that pays 10% on food delivery earns nothing extra when you fill petrol; the card that slashes fuel surcharge does nothing for your electricity bill. So do not choose by the biggest number in the advertisement. Choose by net annual value for your actual spend.

The net-annual-value method

1. Map your real monthly spend by category: online shopping, groceries, food delivery, dining out, fuel, utility bills, travel, and UPI scan-and-pay.
2. For each shortlisted card, read its earn rate in your top two or three categories, and note the monthly or quarterly cap and the exclusions.
3. Value the rewards at their realistic redemption value — not the headline point value the bank quotes.
4. Subtract the annual fee, and check the spend at which it is waived.
5. Pick the card with the highest net value. Two to three cards is the sweet spot: one all-rounder, one category specialist, and optionally one platform or fuel card. More than three becomes hard to track.

Read the MITC — it is the real contract

The Most Important Terms and Conditions (MITC) is the authority for everything that matters: earn rates, caps, excluded categories, annual and late fees, interest rate, and how long reward points last. RBI requires issuers to publish it and give you a copy. Before you apply, search the MITC for the words 'cap', 'exclude' and 'UPI' — those three words decide most of your real reward.

Eligibility and the score that matters

- Most issuers look for a CIBIL score of 750 or above for a clean, document-light approval; entry cards often start around 700–720.
- Salaried applicants usually prove income with salary slips; self-employed applicants with an ITR and bank statements.
- If your profile is thin or new to credit, a secured card against a fixed deposit builds history with almost no risk — the limit is tied to your deposit.
- Do not apply to several issuers in a short window: each application is a hard enquiry on your report.

Fee versus cap: the trap in the headline rate

A 10% rate that stops at a small monthly cap can pay less than a flat 2% with no cap once you spend normally. Always compare cards after applying the caps, not before.

Chapter 3

The 2026 Card Landscape

The tables below summarise the strongest cards in each spending category, verified against issuer terms in October 2026. Rates and caps change often — confirm the current figures in the MITC before you apply or spend. The aim is to show the shape of the market, not to name a winner.

Online shopping

Card	Earn rate	Cap / key condition
Amazon Pay ICICI	5% on Amazon for Prime, 3% non-Prime; 1% other	Lifetime free; rewards as Amazon Pay balance; fuel, rent, EMI, precious metals excluded
SBI Cashback	5% on all online spends	₹2,000 per statement cycle (halved from ₹5,000 on 1 Apr 2026); excludes utilities, insurance, fuel, rent, wallets, education, jewellery, gaming, FASTag, govt
Flipkart Axis	7.5% Myntra; 5% Flipkart and Cleartrip; 1% other	₹4,000 per quarter per merchant; rules updated 28 Aug 2026
HDFC Millennia	5% on listed partner brands; 1% other	₹1,000 per month cap; ₹999 fee waived at ₹1L spend
HDFC Swiggy	10% on Swiggy app; 5% online; 1% other	10%: ₹1,500/mo (min ₹249); 5%: ₹1,500/mo; 1%: ₹500/mo
Jupiter Edge+ (CSB RuPay)	10% on Amazon, Flipkart, Myntra wishlist brands	₹2,000/mo with ₹600 per merchant; lifetime free

Food, dining and groceries

Card	Best for	Earn rate and cap
HDFC Swiggy	Swiggy, Instamart, Dineout	10% (₹1,500/mo)
Zomato RBL	Zomato	10% (₹1,000/mo)
Axis ACE	All-round dining and bills	4% Swiggy/Zomato; 5% utility via Google Pay; 2% other; ₹499 fee
HSBC Live+	Dining, food delivery, groceries combined	10% combined (₹1,200/mo); 1.5% other
Tata Neu Infinity HDFC	BigBasket, bbnov	5% NeuCoins on the Tata ecosystem

Fuel, travel and utilities

Need	Strong cards	Earn rate and cap
Fuel	IndianOil RBL XTRA; BPCL SBI Octane; HDFC IndianOil	Up to 8.5%; 7.25%; 5% + 1% waiver (surcharge-waiver caps apply)
Travel and miles	ICICI MakeMyTrip; Axis Atlas; HDFC Infinia	Co-brand rewards; EDGE Miles; ~3.33% base, up to 10x via SmartBuy (invite-only)
Utility bills	Axis ACE; Axis Airtel	5% via Google Pay; 25% on Airtel bills (capped), 10% other utilities

Need	Strong cards	Earn rate and cap
UPI scan-and-pay	Kiwi Axis RuPay; Tata Neu Infinity RuPay	1.5% uncapped, lifetime free; 5% Tata UPI, 1.5% other

A practical 3-card wallet

Most readers are best served by: (1) one all-rounder that covers bills and dining — Axis ACE or HDFC Millennia; (2) one category specialist for your biggest spend — a fuel card or a grocery card; and (3) one platform or UPI card if you shop or scan heavily. Keep it to three.

Chapter 4

Squeezing Maximum Rewards

A reward programme is a set of rules with three moving parts: the rate, the cap, and the exclusions. Miss any one of them and your effective reward can fall to near zero. Here is how to extract the most from any card without overthinking it.

Caps first, rate second

The cap decides everything above a modest spend. A card that pays 10% but stops at ₹1,500 a month pays exactly ₹18,000 a year and nothing more, however much you spend. Once your monthly spend in the bonus category passes the cap, the remaining spend drops to the base rate — so plan which card to use once each card's cap is exhausted.

The exclusions that quietly erase rewards

Most Indian cards exclude the same categories from earning: fuel, rent, wallet loads, EMI conversions, government and tax payments, jewellery, insurance premiums, education fees, and cash-like or person-to-person transfers. Two cards can look identical on the front page and differ completely once these are applied.

Merchant category codes: why the same shop can earn or not

Rewards are calculated on the merchant category code (MCC) the terminal sends, not on what you bought. A kirana QR may post as retail (earns) or as something else (does not). After you pay a new kind of merchant for the first time, check your statement preview to see whether the transaction earned — one check beats a dozen assumptions.

Redemption: value points honestly, and redeem before a devaluation

- Value points at what you will actually redeem them for — often a fraction of the marketing figure.
- SBI Card, from 1 April 2026, capped statement-credit redemption at 60,000 points per card per calendar month and allows redemption only in multiples of 4,000 points (exceptions: Air India SBI Signature, PhonePe SBI PURPLE and SELECT BLACK). Check your own issuer's redemption multiples and caps.
- Points can expire, and programmes get devalued. RBI gives at least 30 days' notice of adverse changes — so when a devaluation is announced, redeem first and decide about the card second.

The devaluation window is an action window

Banks almost never reverse an announced devaluation, and they cluster their notice at the regulatory floor of 30 days. Treat that notice as your cue to redeem the balance before the cut lands — or to exit the card without a closure charge if the change is against you.

Chapter 5

RuPay Credit Cards on UPI

UPI-on-credit lets you pay a merchant QR code from your credit limit instead of your bank balance. For everyday kirana and supermarket spending that used to go through debit UPI, this turns previously unrewarded payments into earning ones — if you set it up correctly and pay the bill in full.

How it actually works

1. Only RuPay credit cards can be linked to UPI. Visa and Mastercard credit cards cannot be used on standard UPI credit rails as of October 2026.
2. Link the card inside PhonePe, Google Pay, Paytm, BHIM or your bank's own UPI app, and set a separate UPI PIN for the credit account.
3. At checkout, choose the RuPay credit account before scanning. The payment draws on your credit limit and appears on your card statement like any swipe, with the usual grace period if you pay in full.

The rules that catch people out

- Merchant payments only. Credit cards on UPI are blocked from person-to-person transfers by design.
- NPCI allows up to ₹1 lakh per transaction, but your bank may set a lower credit-UPI sub-limit for new linkages.
- Rewards are set by the issuer's MITC — not by NPCI and not by the app. Some cards pay full rates on UPI; others exclude it or pay a reduced rate.
- Your monthly cashback cap is shared across UPI and swipe spend. UPI moves everyday spending onto the card and can push you past the cap faster.
- It is still a credit card: it reports to the credit bureaus, and if you revolve the balance, interest and GST apply exactly as on a swipe.

Verify before you migrate your spending

Search your MITC for the word UPI before you move daily spends onto the card, then check the first statement after linking to confirm the transactions actually earned. Assuming parity with swipes is the most common and most avoidable disappointment.

One discipline point: because a credit-UPI payment feels identical to a debit-UPI payment, it is easy to stop noticing how much you are spending. Set a monthly credit-UPI cap in the app, or move discretionary spending back to debit once you hit your limit.

Chapter 6

Stacking the October 2026 Festive-Sale Offers

The festive sales are the single biggest discount window of the Indian year, and the headline '10% off with the right bank card' is real — but it is capped, has exclusions, and is not always the best card to use. Here is the honest version, verified from the offer terms in October 2026.

The two sales and their bank partners

Sale	Runs	Bank partner	Base cap per order
Amazon Great Indian Festival	8 to 20 Oct 2026	SBI credit / debit cards	₹1,500, then ₹1,250 from 12 Oct; min ₹2,490 (₹4,990 mobiles)
Flipkart Big Billion Days	9 to 18 Oct 2026 (early access 8 Oct)	Axis Bank and ICICI Bank cards	Axis base ₹1,500, then ₹1,250 from 11 Oct; min ₹4,990

The exclusions decide whether you actually get it

- On Amazon, the SBI offer excludes corporate cards, the Paytm SBI, Flipkart SBI and Cashback SBI cards, and RuPay credit cards used through UPI.
- On Amazon, SBI also reclaims the reward points on discounted transactions — so you may trade card rewards for the instant discount.
- On Flipkart, the Flipkart Axis card is excluded from the general offer (it gets a separate EMI-only offer), and Axis excludes UPI and net-banking payments.
- The base discount can be availed a limited number of times, and it resets on set days — Amazon resets on 9, 10, 11, 13, 15, 17 and 19 October; Flipkart resets on 11 and 16 October.

The crossover: when the 10% offer loses to your own card

The SBI base cap of ₹1,500 equals 5% of ₹30,000. Below ₹30,000, the SBI 10% (capped) wins. Above ₹30,000, a 5%-back card — like Amazon Pay ICICI for Prime members — often beats it, unless the bonus offers close the gap. From 12 October, when the SBI cap drops to ₹1,250, the crossover falls to ₹25,000.

The 30-second decision rule

Compare the final price, not the sticker: sale price minus the bank discount, against the rewards your own card would earn. Split a large cart into orders across reset days so the cap applies more than once. And do not accept an EMI offer that forfeits a higher cashback.

Finally, the sale discount is worth chasing only on things you were going to buy anyway. A ₹1,500 discount on a ₹30,000 phone you did not need is not a saving — it is ₹28,500 you just spent.

Chapter 7

The Minimum-Due Trap

Banks print the minimum amount due in a large, friendly font. It feels responsible to pay it. It is the most expensive decision in Indian personal finance, and the maths below shows exactly why.

What the minimum due actually is

It is typically the higher of 5% of your outstanding balance or ₹200–250, plus any EMI instalments due, past-due amounts, overlimit charges and the interest and fees charged that cycle. It is the smallest payment that keeps your account 'current'. It is not a payment plan.

Why the cost explodes

1. Interest is charged on the full outstanding balance from each transaction date — not from the due date.
2. You lose the interest-free period on every new purchase until the full balance is cleared.
3. The rate compounds monthly, and 18% GST is added on top of every finance charge.
4. Most mainstream cards charge 3.25% to 3.75% a month — roughly 39% to 45% a year — which becomes about 48% to 50% once GST is added.

Bank-wise revolving rates (2026)

Issuer / card type	Monthly rate	Approx. APR (with GST)
Premium cards (e.g. HDFC Infinia, SBI Prime Advantage)	1.99%	~28%
ICICI Instant Platinum	2.49%	~35%
SBI Card (standard variants)	3.50%	~49.6%
HDFC (Regalia, Diners)	3.60%	~50%
ICICI (Amazon Pay, Coral)	3.67%	~51%
Axis Bank (Ace, Flipkart, Magnus)	3.60%	~50%
Kotak Mahindra (revised 2025)	3.75%	~53%

The worked example that should end the debate

Take a ₹50,000 balance on a card charging 3.5% a month, and pay only the minimum each month, with no new spending. Because interest keeps compounding on a balance that barely moves, you would pay roughly ₹1.7 to ₹1.9 lakh in total and take about 8 to 10 years to clear it — of which ₹1.2 to ₹1.4 lakh is pure interest, two to three times the original amount. Every month, most of your minimum payment goes to interest and only a small slice touches the principal.

The one comparison to remember

Converting that same ₹50,000 to a 12-month EMI at around 15% costs roughly ₹54,200 in total — a saving of about ₹1.17 lakh versus paying the minimum. The difference between a minimum-due habit and an EMI is not a few hundred rupees. It is over a lakh.

Chapter 8

If You Are Already in the Trap

If you are revolving a balance, do not panic and do not keep paying the minimum. There is a clear order of operations that cuts the cost dramatically, and it works whether your balance is ₹20,000 or ₹2 lakh.

1. Stop new spending on the card. Move to debit or bank-UPI until the balance is clear, so the balance can actually fall.
2. Convert the balance to EMI immediately. Most banks offer conversion at 12–18% a year — HDFC SmartEMI, SBI Flexi Pay, ICICI EMI on Call. On ₹50,000 over 12 months at 15% you pay about ₹54,200 total, versus roughly ₹1.7 lakh if you keep paying the minimum.
3. Or take a personal loan at 11–16% and clear the card outright. It sounds odd to borrow to repay borrowing, but the maths is unambiguous: 12% beats 45%.
4. Or balance-transfer to a cheaper card if one offers a low introductory rate — read the transfer fee and the rate that applies after the intro period.
5. Negotiate a temporary rate reduction with the issuer's retention team. It works some of the time, and is most likely if you have a long, clean history.
6. Once clear, set auto-pay for the total amount due, not the minimum, so it never happens again.

A note on tax

Interest paid on a credit card is generally not tax-deductible, while interest on certain personal or business loans can be. That is one more reason a lower-rate loan often beats revolving a card.

Do not close the card in a hurry

Clearing the balance and then closing the card can hurt your credit score, because it removes available credit (raising your utilisation ratio) and shortens your credit history. Keep the card open, use it lightly — 20% to 30% of the limit — and pay in full every cycle. If the annual fee is the problem, ask for a fee waiver or downgrade rather than closing.

Chapter 9

Your Rights Under RBI's 2026 Rules

RBI's directions on credit cards give you more protection than most cardholders realise. These are the rights worth knowing, and using.

Your right	What it means in practice
Change your billing cycle	You can change the cycle at least once, to any start or closing date, to match your salary and cash flow.
Choose your card network	At a new issue, and at renewal, covered issuers must offer a choice among available card networks. This is not instant mid-term switching.
A minimum-due warning	Statements must warn that paying only the minimum stretches repayment with compounded interest; the MITC must explain that the interest-free period is suspended if a previous balance is outstanding.
No negative amortisation	The minimum due must cover the full interest plus some principal — your balance cannot grow while you pay on time.
Transparent rewards	All cashbacks, points and benefits must be disclosed and verifiable, with details on the issuer's website.
30 days' notice of adverse changes	If a change is to your disadvantage, you get at least 30 days' notice and may surrender the card with no closure charge, subject to clearing dues.
No unilateral limit increase	Issuers cannot raise your credit limit without your explicit consent (OTP or written).
Fairer late-payment rules (from 1 Apr 2027)	A card can be reported past due, or penal charges levied, only if it stays past due for more than 3 days; late charges apply only to the outstanding amount, not the total due.
No capitalising charges	Issuers cannot levy interest on unpaid taxes, levies or charges.

Practical use: if your issuer announces a fee hike or a reward cut you dislike, that 30-day notice is your exit window — redeem your points, then decide whether the card still earns its fee, and if not, surrender it without a closure charge.

Chapter 10

Safety and Fraud: The 10-Minute Checklist

A credit card is only as safe as your habits. Fraud on Indian cards is overwhelmingly the result of a shared secret or a rushed click, not a broken system.

- Never share your OTP, CVV, PIN or full card number with anyone — no bank, no RBI official, no 'courier', and no one who calls about a 'refund' or a 'KYC update'.
- Use only your card app or the number printed on the back of your card. Fake customer-care numbers on search results are a leading fraud channel.
- Turn on transaction alerts by SMS and email, and review your statement every cycle — you are the first line of detection.
- If your card is lost or you spot an unauthorised transaction, block the card and report it immediately through the app or the issuer's helpline.
- RBI's limited-liability framework means your share of the loss on an unauthorised transaction depends heavily on how fast you report — report at once and liability is typically nil; delay and your share grows.
- Prefer tokenised cards in wallets and merchant apps over entering your raw card number, and use the app's lock/unlock and spend-limit controls for online transactions.
- Pay dues only through the issuer's authorised channels — RBI advises against paying through unauthorised modes.
- Be wary of any 'digital arrest', 'loan approved — pay a fee' or 'card upgrade — confirm the OTP' call. None are real.

The 3-step drill if something goes wrong

1. Block the card in the app. 2. Report the unauthorised transaction in writing and keep the reference number. 3. If the issuer does not resolve it, escalate to the RBI's Integrated Ombudsman Scheme — it is free and built for exactly this.

Chapter 11

Build Credit Safely, Raise Your Limit the Smart Way

A well-used card is one of the fastest ways to build a strong credit profile — and a badly used one is the fastest way to wreck it. The habits are simple and the rewards compound.

The habits that build your score

- Pay the full statement, on time, every cycle — the single biggest factor in your score.
- Keep total utilisation under 30% across all cards; under 10% is excellent. High utilisation can cost 30–80 points over six months.
- Do not close your oldest card; the length of your credit history matters.
- Avoid several new applications at once — each is a hard enquiry.

How to raise your credit limit without a needless score hit

There are two routes. A bank-initiated, pre-approved increase is usually a soft enquiry and does not touch your score — accept it in the app. A formal, out-of-cycle request through the app can trigger a hard enquiry that costs about 5–10 points and stays on your report, so time it well.

- Let the bank's periodic review do the work: use 20–30% of your limit and pay in full for at least six consecutive months.
- Update your income with the bank after a raise — banks rarely refresh it on their own, and a higher documented income lifts your ceiling.
- Ask only once every 6–12 months, and only after a full cycle of low utilisation. Requesting while utilisation is high, or right after a missed payment, usually backfires.
- Documents usually asked for: last 2–3 months' salary slips (salaried), or the latest ITR plus 3–6 months' bank statements (self-employed).

The 30-30 rule

Before requesting a limit increase: bring utilisation below 30% for one full billing cycle, document a 30%+ jump in income, and wait 30+ days after any major positive credit event. Hit all three and your odds improve sharply.

Chapter 12

Your 30-Day Action Plan

Week 1 — Audit

- List every card: network, annual fee and its waiver threshold, interest rate, statement date, due date.
- For each card, note the earn rate in your top two categories, the cap, and the exclusions from the MITC.
- Total your reward points and check for any expiry dates this quarter.

Week 2 — Fix

- Set auto-pay for the total amount due on every card. Not the minimum.
- If a balance is revolving, start the escape plan: EMI conversion, personal loan, or balance transfer.
- Ask your main issuer to move your billing cycle so the due date falls just after your salary.

Week 3 — Optimise

- Assign each spending category to the card that wins there, and stop using the wrong card by habit.
- Link a RuPay credit card to UPI if it earns on UPI spends — verify in the MITC first.
- Before your next big purchase, compare the festive bank offer against your own card's earn using the crossover rule.

Week 4 — Automate and protect

- Turn on transaction alerts and app lock/unlock; set online spend limits.
- Redeem expiring points; if a devaluation was announced, redeem before it lands.
- If your income rose, update it with the bank; if utilisation is under 30%, request a limit increase the smart way.

Printable: your monthly card health-check

- ☐ Paid every card in full by the due date ☐ Utilisation under 30% ☐ Points checked for expiry
☐ No category spends above their cap ☐ Statements reviewed for errors ☐ Alerts on ☐ No new balance revolving

Appendix A**AI Prompt Pack**

Copy these into any AI assistant (ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude) to turn the method into a personal plan. Replace the brackets with your own numbers. Do not enter your card number, CVV, OTP or PIN into any AI tool.

Pick my best card

I spend about ₹[amount] a month, split roughly: online shopping [%], groceries [%], food delivery [%], dining [%], fuel [%], utilities [%], UPI scans [%]. I want to maximise rewards without an annual fee over ₹[amount]. Compare the cards that fit and show me the net annual value after caps and exclusions.

Decode a card's MITC

Here is the rewards section of a card's MITC: [paste text]. Summarise in a table: the earn rate per category, the monthly or quarterly cap, the excluded categories, and anything that applies specifically to UPI spends.

Festive-sale decision

I am buying a [product] for ₹[amount] on [Amazon/Flipkart] during the festive sale. I hold [card A] and [card B]. Work out the final price with the bank offer versus the rewards my own card would earn, and tell me which is cheaper and why.

Minimum-due escape plan

I have a ₹[amount] balance revolving at [rate]% a month on a card. Compare paying the minimum versus converting to a 12-month EMI at [rate]% versus a personal loan at [rate]%, and give me the total cost and the cheapest realistic path.

Statement audit

Here is my card statement summary for the month: [paste the category totals]. Identify where my rewards are below what my cards should pay, and which spends hit a cap or an exclusion.

Billing-cycle timing

My statement closes on the [date] and the due date is the [date]. My salary arrives on the [date]. Suggest the best billing-cycle change under RBI rules and when I should time large purchases for the longest interest-free period.

Reward-point value

I have [number] points on [card]. I can redeem them for statement credit, vouchers or air miles. Compare the real value of each option per point and tell me the best use.

Limit-increase script

Write me a short, polite request to my bank's app chat asking for a credit-limit increase, given that I have paid in full for [months] months, my utilisation is [%], and my income rose to ₹[amount] a month.

Appendix B

Cheat Sheet and Glossary

The one-page cheat sheet

Situation	What to do
Normal month	Pay the full statement by the due date. Set auto-pay for the total, not the minimum.
Want the longest free credit	Buy at the start of the billing cycle; change the cycle to sit after your salary.
Big purchase in a festive sale	Compare bank discount (after its cap) against your own card's earn; split across reset days.
Balance you cannot clear this month	Convert to EMI immediately; do not let it revolve at 40%+.
Already revolving	Stop new spending, convert to EMI or a personal loan, then set auto-pay for the full amount.
Choosing a card	Compare after caps and exclusions, not the headline rate. Keep to 2-3 cards.
An adverse change is announced	Redeem points before it lands; exit the card with no closure charge if it no longer earns its fee.
Lost card or fraud	Block in the app, report immediately, keep the reference, escalate to the RBI Ombudsman if unresolved.

Glossary

APR — Annual Percentage Rate — the yearly cost of borrowing, including the effect of monthly compounding.

Billing cycle — The period between two statement dates, usually about 30 days.

Cap — The maximum reward or discount a card pays in a period; beyond it, the base rate or zero applies.

CIBIL — India's main credit bureau; your score (300–900) summarises your repayment behaviour.

Grace period — The interest-free window on a card, provided the previous balance is fully cleared.

MCC — Merchant Category Code — the code a terminal sends, which decides whether a spend earns.

Minimum amount due — The smallest payment that keeps the account current; not a repayment plan.

MITC — Most Important Terms and Conditions — the authoritative document for a card's rates, caps and fees.

Revolving credit — Carrying a balance month to month; the most expensive way to use a card.

Utilisation ratio — Outstanding balance as a percentage of your total limit; keep it under 30%.

Frequently asked questions

Will paying only the minimum due hurt my credit score?

Not immediately — it keeps the account current and avoids a late fee. But it pushes utilisation high, which can drag your score down over months, and it is by far the most expensive way to borrow.

Is the 10% festive-sale discount always the best option?

No. It is capped per order, has exclusions, and on Amazon SBI reclaims your reward points. Above roughly ₹30,000 a 5%-back card often beats it. Compare the final price.

Can I use any credit card on UPI?

Only RuPay credit cards can be linked to UPI as of October 2026. Visa and Mastercard credit cards cannot.

Should I close a card I no longer use?

Usually no. Closing it removes available credit and shortens your history. Keep it open with light use and ask for a fee waiver if the fee is the issue.

Are reward points guaranteed to keep their value?

No. Programmes get devalued, though RBI requires at least 30 days' notice of adverse changes. Redeem regularly and watch for devaluation notices.

The Smart Credit Card Playbook 2026 — India Edition. Published by Digitalaikart. Every card rate, cap, rule and offer was verified against official issuer terms, RBI directions and platform offer pages in October 2026. Credit card terms change frequently — confirm the current terms in your card's MITC before you apply or spend. This guide is educational and is not personalised financial advice.